



"Western Vs Regional Media Coverage of Syrian Coast Alawite Massacre"

Nour Wehbi

Dr Marwa Osman

Reporting practices (JDM220)

Table of Contents

Abstract	3
Introduction.....	4
Literature Review.....	6
Content Analysis.....	10
Evaluation	13
Conclusion	14
References	15

Abstract

This content analysis is to show how Western vs regional media outlets have covered the Alawite civilian massacre on the Syrian coast carried by Hayaat Tahrir al-Sham in 2025, comparing how Western media like CNN, BBC, and The New York Times (that often looks at the political and military sides) reported versus how regional channels like Al Jazeera, Al Mayadeen, and Al Akhbar presented the story that highlighted the victims or local context more deeply. That's by focusing on the words used while reporting, the tone of their reporting, and how they framed the coverage of the stories. This shapes the audiences' perceptions and points of view because the way a story is told can affect how people around the world understand what happened.

Keywords: Syria, Syrian coast, Alawite massacre, western media, regional media, Hayat Tahrir al-Sham, media coverage.

Introduction

The media plays a big role in how people around the world understand conflicts especially when they can't access the conflict. For many, international news outlets like CNN, BBC, and The New York Times are the main sources of information about worldwide events. These Western media outlets have a strong influence, often shaping how audiences think about places and people they've never met making specific stereotypes for each idea they present. (COLAKOGLU , TURAN , & COLAKOGLU , 2007)¹ But with this power comes the risk of bias through the words they use, the tone they take, and the parts of the story they choose to highlight or ignore.

Syria is one country that has been deeply affected by both conflict and media attention. After gaining independence in the mid-1900s, Syria comes under the control of the Assad family in the 1970s. Hafez al Assad, and later his son Bashar al Assad, ruled with a strong grip, especially relying on the support of the Alawite minority—an offshoot of Shia Islam. For many years, people in Syria lived under tight government control, and speaking out was dangerous. (Seale, 1989)²

Then came the Arab Spring in 2011, when Syrians like people in other Arab countries began protesting for freedom and change. The government responded with violence, and this led to a long and bloody civil war. Many groups are involved, including rebels,

¹ COLAKOGLU , S., TURAN , A. H., & COLAKOGLU , B. E. (2007). Western Influence on South Korean Media: The Case of Turkey's Representation. *The World Congress for Korean Studies*, (p. 31). Busan, South Korea.

https://www.academia.edu/44395294/Western_Influence_on_South_Korean_Media_The_Case_of_Turkeys_Representation

² Seale, P. (1989). *Asad: The Struggle for the Middle East*. University of California Press.

https://www.amazon.com/dp/0520069765/ref=as_at?tag=fivebooks001-20

extremist fighters, and foreign armies. Over the years, Syria became a battlefield full of suffering, destruction, and division. (Smith & Ochsenwald, 2025)³

In late 2024, protests began again in Syria. People were frustrated with poverty, corruption, and lack of change. By early 2025, tensions had risen again, and a terrible event took place which was the Alawite massacre. The group "Hayaat Tahrir al-Sham", a hardline Islamist faction, attacked Alawite villages along the Syrian coast, killing many civilians. It was one of the deadliest sectarian attacks in recent years, and it caught the world's attention.

But when people around the world read about it, they didn't all get the same version of the story.

This paper looks at how the same tragic massacre of Alawite civilians was covered by both Western and regional media. While Western outlets often report from a distance focused more on the broader conflict or on the group behind the attack, regional channels like Al Jazeera, Al Mayadeen, and Al Akhbar are closer to the story geographically and culturally focusing more on the victims and the political history behind it. By comparing how these two groups of media covered the same event, we can better understand the different ways they tell stories, how it changes perceptions, and why it matters, focusing on their tone, language, and the framing used in their coverage, showing how media can shape the way they see and report tragedy and conflict. Then, how did Western and regional media differ in their coverage of the Syrian coast Alawite massacre?

³ Smith, C. G., & Ochsenwald, W. L. (2025, March 23). *Britannica*. Retrieved from britannica.com: <https://www.britannica.com/place/Syria>

<https://www.britannica.com/place/Syria>

Literature Review

When searching for the title of the 2025 Syrian coast Alawite massacre in Western and regional media, it reveals that most of the Western news is trying to hide the political and historical sides of the story trying to frame it. Unlike the regional news outlets that tend to embed such violence within broader geopolitical or sectarian frameworks. Thus, the outlets shape the story and the public perceptions according to their agenda.

This sums up different news that was covered by both outlets that reported the same event but in different ways according to different goals where the content of the article heads to a specific target that serves the agenda-setting of each outlet.

In the BBC's article "Syrians describe terror as Alawite families killed in their homes" they stated the event in a humanitarian way by interviewing an Alawite man using the emotional and journalistic tone and direct quotations from victims to evoke empathy. However, the article avoids explicitly labeling the event as a sectarian massacre or directly criticizing the role of international powers, which may suggest editorial caution or bias through omission. That was by the usage of specific statements such as "Islamist-led forces" and "areas loyal to ousted former leader Bashar al Assad". (Sinjab, March 2025)⁴

CNN's article about the 2025 Alawite massacre titled "'Ethnic cleansing!' Videos show Syrian government-aligned forces reveling in the massacre of minorities in coastal town" uses strong and emotional language that can show a kind of hidden bias. The report focuses on disturbing videos showing armed men celebrating after killing civilians from minority groups in a Syrian coastal town. Although CNN was focusing on victims, they described the attackers as "government-aligned forces. Also, by using dramatic words like "reveling" and "massacre," the article makes the event seem more shocking without

⁴ Sinjab, L. (March 2025). *Syrians describe terror as Alawite families killed in their homes*. Damascus, Syria: BBC.

explaining deeper reasons and background behind the violence focusing on certain parts and leaving out others. (Qiblawi, El Sirgany, Goodwin, & Mezzofiore, March 2025)⁵

The New York Times article “*Syria Alawite Killings Spark Human Rights Outcry*” presents the 2025 Alawite massacre through a lens that reflects typical Western media framing. It exceeds the report of the victims' personal stories or the cultural and sectarian tensions behind the attack to emphasize international responses. The formal tone avoids emotional descriptions and goes straight to the bigger political implications. Words like “reported violence” and “alleged killings” distance the outlet from the event and can reduce the tragedy’s emotional impact and also suggest caution or neutrality. (Ward, March 2025)⁶

Al Jazeera’s article, “Dozens reported killed as Syrian forces and pro-Assad fighters clash,” shows a different view compared to other Western outlets. The outlet didn't just mention facts but also emphasized the event to show the reality of what happened to give a better understanding. The report highlights the violence and the struggle of survivors, and a deep vision of Syrian society using clear terms. While the article does mention some political background, its main focus is on the people affected by the violence. They mixed between facts and kept the seriousness of the event as it was. (Dozens reported killed as Syrian forces and pro-Assad fighters clash, March 2025)⁷

⁵ *‘Ethnic cleansing!’ Videos show Syrian government-aligned forces reveling in massacre of minorities in coastal town.* CNN .

<https://edition.cnn.com/2025/03/17/middleeast/syria-massacre-alawite-minority-intl-invs>

⁶ Ward, E. (March 2025). *Syria Violence Marked by Sectarian and Revenge Killings, War Monitor Says.* Beirut, Lebanon: The New York Times.

<https://www.nytimes.com/2025/03/12/world/europe/syria-alawite-killings-human-rights.html>

⁷ March 2025). *Dozens reported killed as Syrian forces and pro-Assad fighters clash.* Al Jazeera .

Al Mayadeen's article "Syrian Alawites Live in Fear Amid Ongoing Violence, reprisal" takes a distinctly human-centered approach, focusing on the emotions, fears, and daily struggles of Alawite civilians following the 2025 massacre. While Western outlets often prioritize institutional and political reactions, Al Mayadeen, by contrast, immerses viewers in the lived experiences of the wounded and those on the ground through powerful, emotionally resonant language such as "fear", "retaliation", and "uncertainty". The article highlighted the fact that the Alawite community is in an ongoing crisis and used a specific empathetic technique that offers a more profound cultural and political background that is missed by Western media. (Syrian Alawites live in fear amid ongoing violence, reprisals: WashPo, 2025)⁸

Al-Akhbar's article "Sharaa Forces Drop Barrels on Coastal Residents: The Shadow of Sectarian Conflict Looms" offers a strong and emotionally charged coverage of the violence affecting Syria's coastal communities, with a focus on the Alawite population. The language is direct, using terms like "barrel bombs" and "sectarian war." Unlike Western outlets that often use more limited language and emphasize the geopolitical side, this article highlights the human cost and the social consequences of the attacks. Using a tone that shows the size of the event and calling out for justice. (قوات الشرع تسقط)

<https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2025/3/7/dozens-reported-killed-as-syrian-forces-and-pro-assad-fighters-clash>

⁸ (2025). *Syrian Alawites live in fear amid ongoing violence, reprisals: WashPo*. Al Mayadeen English.

<https://english.almayadeen.net/news/politics/syrian-alawites-live-in-fear-amid-ongoing-violence--reprisal>

Sharaa Forces Drop Barrels on Coastal Residents: The Shadow of Sectarian Conflict Looms)⁹

⁹ Sharaa Forces Drop Barrels on Coastal Residents: The Shadow of Sectarian Conflict Looms. (n.d.). *Al-Akhbar*.

<https://www.al-akhbar.com/arab/825888/%D9%82%D9%88%D8%A7%D8%AA-%D8%A7%D9%84%D8%B4%D8%B1%D8%B9-%D8%AA%D8%B3%D9%82%D8%B7-%D8%A7%D9%84%D8%A8%D8%B1%D8%A7%D9%85%D9%8A%D9%84-%D8%B9%D9%84%D9%89-%D8%B3%D9%83%D8%A7%D9%86-%D8%A7%D9%84%D8%B3%D8%A7%D8%AD%D9%84--%D8%B4%D8%A8%D8%AD-%D8%A7%D9%82%D8%AA%D8%AA%D8%A7%D9%84-%D8%B7%D8%A7%D8%A6%D9%81%D9%8A-%D9%81>

Content Analysis

Western and regional media outlets tend to share news as a part of the agenda not only for sharing the truth but also for reflecting their stans by highlighting certain facts and framing the way people interpret the story.

BBC News highlights the event trying to stand on the stans by emotionally attracting the audience through the featured case about “Mr. Ayman fares” and why his life was saved, describing the event in detail. On the other hand, BBC uses specific words or facts that are not that true or in their place. For example, “Syria's interim leader has appealed for unity, as violence and revenge killings continued in areas loyal to ousted former leader Bashar al-Assad on Sunday.” these areas are not loyal to al Assad but it's an area that is known and full of Alawites which is the sect Assad belongs to. Also, the usage of “Islamist led forces” in the sentence “He was arrested soon after, and only released when Islamist-led forces freed prisoners after Assad's fall last December.” instead of Takfiri or terrorist groups show their selective usage of words.

CNN's article about the 2025 Alawite massacre uses strong and emotional language that can show a kind of hidden bias. CNN News emphasizes the sectarian nature of the violence of families that were terrified by the event, highlighting that the armed forces of Syria's new Islamist government are attacking the victims using a range of credible sources like eyewitness testimonies. They maintained an objective view. Also, they mentioned that “A masked fighter filmed himself parading around the ransacked home, singing “ethnic cleansing, ethnic cleansing” and posted the video to his Facebook page for 28,000 followers to see. Family members hiding in the upper floor told CNN they heard the raid, including the executions, unfold.” using terms such as “ethnic cleansing,” providing insights into the complexity of the conflict and mentioning the history of the sectarian tension and the Alawite community.

New York Times provides a less emphasized version but also talks about the violence and human impact of the event, showing the fear and trauma caused by the attacks but also focusing on political crises and hidden goals with credible sources like human

rights organizations and eyewitnesses. Which makes it a more reliable narrative with balanced coverage of the event. While the language used is measured without using sensitive terms. But also highlights the political context and relating it to Bashar Assad and the tension regarding this point. The article demonstrates a balance between providing facts and analytical context, with balanced writing without using sensitive language.

Unlike Western media outlets, Al Jazeera's article offers a more real look at the recent violence trying to provide ethical coverage that reaches the readers in a more human way to make an impact. It is different because it didn't just focus on military movements but also the suffering of the civilians and innocent people focusing on a more regional view and describing the event as the "deadliest violence since opposition fighters toppled the regime last year. ". Mentioning the numbers of killings in several villages in Latakia, meanwhile highlighting several points regarding the political perspectives. Al Jazeera's language is emotionally resonant but not sensational, aiming to balance facts with compassion. Al Jazeera offers a more comprehensive view of what's happening in Syria making the coverage more ethical and full of facts that will send the real tragedy to readers internationally. By doing so, it connects the tragedy in Syria to international audiences in a way that feels immediate, urgent, and real.

Al Mayadeen provided the most human side of the conflict focusing on the tragedy and suffering of citizens and how it affected the whole community. They focused more on using terms such as "genocide" than talking about politics. They cover the story of victims who were killed in this ethnic cleansing act and highlight how violence was the base of this massacre. It uses emotional words like "fear," and "retaliation," to show what life is like for these communities. Shows how families are living in fear of being killed at any time just because they're listed as connected to Bashar Al Assad's old government or just Alawites, and it points out how the promises made by the new leaders, like Hayaat Tahrir al-Sham, are falling short. This shows that the promises of the new government of safety don't relate to these people. Focusing on real people's experiences made al Mayadeen the one that covered the event not mentioning only the

political point of view. Which helps readers understand the situation making the article more relatable and easier to connect with emotionally.

Al Akhbar's article, "Sharaa's Forces Drop Barrels on Coastal Residents: The Specter of Sectarian Conflict Looms Over Syria," focuses on the fear and tragedy of the Alawite community in Syria. It describes how the new Syrian leadership of Ahmad alSharaa has been bombing coastal areas, leaving Alawite civilians scared and not knowing anything about their future. The tone shows the struggle and community trauma. Through this framing, Al-Akhbar positions the event within a regional context that is emotionally clear for its audience, contributing to a better understanding of the massacre. The article shares real stories of people and the acts of violence on them. Using strong words like "sectarian war" to show how serious the situation is.

Evaluation

The analysis of Western vs regional media coverage from CNN, Al Jazeera, The New York Times, Al Mayadeen, and Al Akhbar on the 2025 Alawite massacre shows true differences in how each outlet covered and framed the massacre regarding the usage of terms, narratives, and priorities. Western outlets like CNN and The New York Times focus on political conflict and some of them focus on the human side while avoiding the sensitivity of the event and usage of terms it is more balanced and limited. While regional outlets like Al Jazeera, Al Mayadeen, and Al Akhbar offer a more regionally grounded and human-centered approach. They emphasize the lived experiences of Alawite civilians, using emotional language and highlighting fears, losses, and struggles. Focusing on violence and unacceptable behavior provides readers with a fully understandable view of suffering. All outlets used credible and reliable sources but at the same the difference between how the readers will understand the conflict is obvious.

Conclusion

This research paper analyzed how Western and regional media outlets covered the 2025 Alawite massacre on the Syrian coast. It compares reports from organizations like CNN, BBC, and The New York Times with regional channels such as Al Jazeera, Al Mayadeen, and Al Akhbar, it becomes clear that each group of media tells a different version of the same story. Western outlets often focused on the larger political and military context, using careful language and prioritizing official responses. Their tone was more reserved, and while they highlighted the human cost, it was usually placed around a broader, more detached framework. In contrast, regional media channels placed more emphasis on the human side of the tragedy, describing the experiences of civilians with emotion and reality. They used powerful words like “fear,” “retaliation,” and “genocide” to share real people suffering with readers. Their coverage included personal stories, community struggles, and the social impact of the violence. This human-based approach created a deeper understanding of how the massacre affected Alawite civilians and their communities, beyond just the political headlines.

Overall, this analysis highlights how media framing can influence public perception. The language, tone, and focus of a report shape how audiences interpret an event, especially in a conflict zone like Syria. While Western media provides structure and credibility, regional outlets bring in the voices and emotions of those directly affected. Both are important, but only by considering multiple perspectives can readers gain a fuller picture of the truth behind such tragedies. This case comparison shows how critical it is to approach media reports with awareness and to recognize how framing influences what we believe about global events.

References

COLAKOGLU , S., TURAN , A. H., & COLAKOGLU , B. E. (2007). Western Influence on South Korean Media: The Case of Turkey's Representation. *The World Congress for Korean Studies*, (p. 31). Busan, South Korea.

https://www.academia.edu/44395294/Western_Influence_on_South_Korean_Media_The_Case_of_Turkeys_Representation

(March 2025). *Dozens reported killed as Syrian forces and pro-Assad fighters clash*. Al Jazeera .

<https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2025/3/7/dozens-reported-killed-as-syrian-forces-and-pro-assad-fighters-clash>

Qiblawi, T., El Sirgany, S., Goodwin, A., & Mezzofiore, G. (March 2025). *'Ethnic cleansing!' Videos show Syrian government-aligned forces reveling in massacre of minorities in coastal town*. CNN .

<https://edition.cnn.com/2025/03/17/middleeast/syria-massacre-alawite-minority-intl-invs>

Seale, P. (1989). *Asad: The Struggle for the Middle East*. University of California Press.

https://www.amazon.com/dp/0520069765/ref=as_at?tag=fivebooks001-20

Sinjab, L. (March 2025). *Syrians describe terror as Alawite families killed in their homes*. Damascus, Syria: BBC.

<https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/cx20p0pj931o>

Smith, C. G., & Ochsenwald, W. L. (2025, March 23). *Britannica*. Retrieved from britannica.com: <https://www.britannica.com/place/Syria>

<https://www.britannica.com/place/Syria>

(2025). *Syrian Alawites live in fear amid ongoing violence, reprisals: WashPo*. Al Mayadeen English.

<https://english.almayadeen.net/news/politics/syrian-alawites-live-in-fear-amid-ongoing-violence--reprisal>

Ward, E. (March 2025). *Syria Violence Marked by Sectarian and Revenge Killings, War Monitor Says*. Beirut, Lebanon: The New York Times.

<https://www.nytimes.com/2025/03/12/world/europe/syria-alawite-killings-human-rights.html>

Sharaa Forces Drop Barrels on Coastal Residents: The Shadow of Sectarian Conflict Looms. (n.d.). *Al-Akhbar*.
شبابا قواا الشراا اسقاا البراميل على سكان الساحل: شباا اقناال طائفيا فوق سوريا

<https://www.al-akhbar.com/arab/825888/%D9%82%D9%88%D8%A7%D8%AA-%D8%A7%D9%84%D8%B4%D8%B1%D8%B9-%D8%AA%D8%B3%D9%82%D8%B7-%D8%A7%D9%84%D8%A8%D8%B1%D8%A7%D9%85%D9%8A%D9%84-%D8%B9%D9%84%D9%89-%D8%B3%D9%83%D8%A7%D9%86-%D8%A7%D9%84%D8%B3%D8%A7%D8%AD%D9%84--%D8%B4%D8%A8%D8%AD-%D8%A7%D9%82%D8%AA%D8%AA%D8%A7%D9%84-%D8%B7%D8%A7%D8%A6%D9%81%D9%8A-%D9%81>